Corpus: legends of kings → Hebrew (Gen 11 and Exod 2)

Read `../translation-guidelines.md` first, then this file, then the shared `renderings.md` (binding), then `translator-brief--kings.md`, then the project's `project.md`.

Goal (Round 2, run 6 of `../curated-translation-candidates.md`, 2026-10-21)

Translate, complete, two legends that the ancient Near East told about its kings and their beginnings:

1. **Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta** (ETCSL 1.8.2.3; Sumerian; composed in the Ur III or early Old Babylonian
   period, copied in the OB schools of Nippur and Ur; 641 composite entries). Enmerkar, king of Uruk and "son of Utu",
   asks Inana to make the distant highland city of Aratta send gold, silver and lapis lazuli and its craftsmen to build
   her temple in Uruk and Enki's Abzu in Eridu. A messenger runs back and forth across seven mountain ranges; the two
   kings exchange threats and riddles (the grain carried in nets; a sceptre of no known material; a champion of no
   colour); the messenger's mouth grows "heavy", and Enmerkar invents writing on clay; Iškur's storm brings wild wheat
   to Aratta; the end (damaged) seems to settle the contest by trade. Inside the first message: **the "spell of
   Nudimmud"** (134–155), on a time when all peoples addressed Enlil "in one tongue" until Enki "placed a different
   tongue in their mouth".

2. **The Sargon Birth Legend** (Neo-Assyrian / Neo-Babylonian Akkadian; K 3401 + Sm 2118 and K 4470 from Nineveh, the
school extract BM 47449 from Babylon; K 7249 not available to us). Sargon of Akkad (c. 2334–2279 BCE) tells in the
first person how his mother, an *ēnetu* (high priestess?), conceived and bore him in secret, set him in a reed
basket sealed with bitumen and cast him on the river; Aqqi the water-drawer drew him out, raised him as his son and
made him a gardener; Ištar loved him and he became king; then the list of his deeds and a challenge to every later
king. Probably composed under Sargon II of Assyria (722–705 BCE), the namesake who claimed the old king's heritage.

Two purposes (guidelines §1)

- **Bible comparison.** For Enmerkar: **Gen 11:1–9** (one language, the confusion of tongues, the bricks, the building
that reaches heaven, the scattering), Gen 10 (the tables of nations "by their tongues"; Erech/Uruk in Nimrod's
kingdom, 10:10), Zeph 3:9 (שָׂפָה בְרוּרָה), Isa 11:6–9 and 65:25 (the peace among the beasts), **Exod 4:10**
(כְּבַד פֶּה), the messengers and their formulas (Gen 32:4–6; Num 20:14–17; Judg 11:12–28; 2 Kgs 18–19), the
writing of the word (Exod 24:12; 32:15–16; Deut 27:8; Isa 8:1; Jer 36; Hab 2:2), the famine and the grain (Gen 41–
47), the rain from the god (Deut 11:10–17), the contest of kings by riddles (1 Kgs 10:1–13; Judg 14). For Sargon:
Exod 2:1–10 (the Levite mother, the hidden child, the papyrus box daubed with bitumen and pitch, the river, the
child drawn out, adopted as a son and named), Exod 1:22 (the river), 2:16–19 (Moses drawing water), the exposed or
hidden child (Gen 21:15–19; 2 Kgs 11:2–3), Gen 10:8–12 (Nimrod and Akkad), Isa 20:1 (Sargon II), the boasts of kings
(Isa 10:8–14; 37:24–25) and the challenge to successors (Deut 17:14–20 inverted).

- **The soul of the ancients**, equal in standing. Kingship and its legitimation (the king chosen in the goddess's
  heart; the king as son of the sun-god; a usurper who tells his own humble birth); rivalry and prestige between a
  river-plain city without stone or metal and a mountain city full of them (the economy of luxury goods; diplomacy by
  messenger and riddle); how they imagined the origin of writing (because a mouth grew tired) and of the many
  languages (a god's act; a golden age, or a hope?); the gods' household (Inana between two lords; Enki's wisdom;
  Nisaba's house of wisdom; Iškur's storm); the messenger's craft (memorizing word for word); the school that copied
  and loved these texts; a king's autobiography as a literary form (*narû*); the foundling, the gardener and the
  goddess's love.

The projects

#	Project folder	Text	Base text	Lines	Files
1	`1-אנמרכר-ואדון-ארטה/`	Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta	ETCSL 1.8.2.3 (`../sources/ETCSL/1.8.2.3-...`); ORACC Q000369 lemma + morph; Mittermayer 2009 (open access)	641 (1–636 with 11A, 106A, 185A, 185B, 365B and the alternative lines A–D of one manuscript for 400–403; ETCSL has no 369, 608–610)	`annotated-1.rtl.md` (1–155), `annotated-2.rtl.md` (156–307), `annotated-3.rtl.md` (308–469), `annotated-4.rtl.md` (470–636)
2	`2--אגדת-הולדת-סרגון/`	The Sargon Birth Legend	King 1907 vol. II pp. 87–96, transcribed from the page images (`../sources/King-1907--...`); eBL catalogue	49 (King's col. I 1–32, col. II 1–17)	`annotated.rtl.md`

Rank 3: ETCSL's English and Mittermayer 2009's German (EA); King 1907's English and the few lines of Westenholz 1997
quoted on the web (SB). Not available: Cohen 1973, Vanstiphout 2003, Westenholz 1997, Lewis 1980 (records:
`../sources/_records-only--Legends-of-kings/`).

Reading order for the commentary: EA 1–64 (Uruk and Aratta; the plea) → 65–155 (Inana's answer; the command; the
spell of Nudimmud) → 156–307 (the first exchange) → 308–455 (the grain and the sceptre) → 456–556 (the champion, the
heavy mouth and the first letter; the storm) → 557–636 (the end) → SB I 1–12 (the birth, the basket, the river, Aqqi,
Ištar) → SB I 13–32, II (the deeds, the challenge, the beasts).

Shared conventions

- **`renderings.md` binds both projects**; it inherits the temple, lament and creation corpora's Sumerian renderings
  and the flood and law corpora's Akkadian ones (§0 there), and the rule "a Sumerian word takes the Hebrew of its
  Akkadian equivalent" — which here makes the two texts meet (Sum. *bal* "cross" and Akk. *nabalkutu* = חָצָה;
  kur₂ and *nakāru* = שָׁנָה; *eme* and *lišānu* = לָשׁוֹן).
- **Repeated lines get identical Hebrew** (command → delivery, the journey, the messenger's greeting, "say to him"):
  `kings_tools.py pars EA FROM TO` lists each line's earlier copies with their Hebrew; `verify` checks the fixed
  formulas and lists identical transliterations with different Hebrew.
- **The annotated file is the only source of the Hebrew**: `kings_tools.py build KEY` generates `translation.rtl.md`.
- **Parallels index:** per file in `project.md` (`### Parallels index (<KEY>)`, KEY = EA1 … EA4, SB; columns exactly
  `| Line | Source | Hebrew rendering | Bible | Tag | Comment |`), merged into `parallels-index.md` by `build_parallels_index.py` (Genesis first, then Exodus).
- **How this run was done (2026-10-21):** the cloud session had no sub-agent tool, so the coordinator worked through
  the translator chain itself, strictly in order (EA1 → EA2 → EA3 → EA4, then SB), each part drafted from its data file
  with the earlier parts' Hebrew in front of it, the proposals merged into `renderings.md` §9 after each part, and the
  three review passes done per part.

Tools (in this folder)

Script	What
`kings_tools.py verify KEY [--strict]`	Entries against the base line list, transliteration = base text, one `>` per entry, reserved and gated strings (renderings §5), name traps (lines and headings), fixed formulas, translation = `>` lines, identical lines with different Hebrew.
`kings_tools.py build KEY`	The clean translation, verified.
`kings_tools.py grep KEY|all '<regex>'` ; `lines KEY FROM-TO` ; `pars KEY FROM TO`	How a Hebrew string was used so far (all = + the lament, temple and creation corpora's Sumerian texts); the base lines; the earlier copies of a repeated line with their Hebrew.
`kings_tools.py conc EA [out]` ; `data EA FROM TO out`	ETCSL ↔ ORACC concordance; a translator's line data (ETCSL, ORACC lemma + morph, ETCSL and Mittermayer at the line).
`build_parallels_index.py`	`parallels-index.md` from the per-file tables.

Status

#	Project	Status
1	Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta	in progress
2	The Sargon Birth Legend	in progress